

SIMPLICITY ITSELF

PLOTINUS ON THE ONE AND INTELLECT

Here's a trivia question you won't hear at any pub-quiz night: what do armies, houses, sunflowers, and giraffes have in common? Things painted by Van Gogh, perhaps? No. He inexplicably failed to capture the noble giraffe in any of his artworks, and I don't believe he was particularly keen on armies either. The right answer is that all these things are mentioned at the beginning of Plotinus' treatise *On the One* (6.9.1), which was placed at the very end of the *Enneads* by his student and editor Porphyry. Actually, he doesn't mention sunflowers or giraffes by name, speaking instead generally of plants and animals, but I think we all know at least which animal he had in mind. He mentions these things because of something else they have in common: they are all one. Without unity an army would just be a bunch of people standing around with an alarming amount of weaponry. And nothing can be a giraffe without being one giraffe. Indeed, to qualify as a thing of any kind is to be *one* thing—unity is a condition of being.

On the other hand, not everything possesses unity to the same degree. Though you might say that each army is one army just as much as each sunflower is one sunflower, armies clearly have less unity than sunflowers. Like all plants and animals, the bodies of sunflowers and giraffes are animated by an internal principle of life. This explains their ability to nourish themselves, to turn towards the sun, or lope gracefully towards tasty acacia leaves. By contrast, things like armies and houses have unity imposed upon them, by generals or house-builders. Aristotle would say that such things have their unity accidentally and from outside, whereas living organisms have an innate, essential unity. Plotinus would agree, and infer a general metaphysical principle: the more unity something has, the more reality it has, and vice versa. An army is a being to a lesser extent than a sunflower, even if it is considerably more dangerous than a sunflower.

Plotinus points out in this same passage that good conditions like health and beauty are also cases of unity (6.9.1). What is health, after all, other than the

cooperative ordering of the body's parts, while illness is the result of these parts coming into conflict with one another? What is beauty but a kind of harmony? And what is harmony but a kind of unity? The same is true even for the human soul, at least according to Plato. It has parts, and the virtuous soul is the soul that achieves harmony and unity through the unchallenged mastery of its rational part.¹ Or consider, finally, the entire cosmos. Nowadays science has arguably exposed the physical universe as something of a chaotic mess, though some think that there is a divine plan behind the apparent chaos. But in antiquity almost everyone, with the notable exception of the Epicureans, considered the universe to be well ordered and unified. Plato compared it to a single animal (*Timaeus* 30b–d), and Aristotle finished his inquiry into how God moves the heavens by quoting Homer: “the rule of many is not one; let there be one ruler” (*Metaphysics* 1076a).

These considerations lead Plotinus to an inescapable conclusion: if we are looking for the source of all things, we should be looking for a source of unity that is itself maximally one. It will also be the source of goodness, beauty, harmony, and order. It will be that from which all else derives and towards which all things strive to return in whatever way they can. Plotinus calls it “the One” or “the Good.” Of course, these ideas do not derive exclusively from Plotinus, the way all things are meant to derive from the One. Looking back as far as Parmenides, we have the idea of reducing reality to a principle of unity. Plato introduces a Form of the Good in the *Republic*, and makes it the source of intelligibility and value for all other Forms. We then come even closer to Plotinus' conception in the Old Academy and Middle Platonists, who try various ways of putting a principle of unity at the top of their metaphysical systems.²

Plotinus recognizes all these intellectual debts, especially the ones to Parmenides and Plato. It is telling, though, that he does not begin this treatise *On the One* by surveying previous opinions, as Aristotle might have done. Instead, he starts with armies and houses, sunflowers and giraffes. Similarly, he says in another treatise on the topic of the One that we should start our inquiry not with the ultimate principle, but by thinking about ourselves (6.8.1). This is part of what distinguishes Plotinus from his predecessors among the so-called “Middle Platonists”—at least, as far as we can tell, given how incompletely we know them. Plotinus does offer detailed expositions of Platonic dialogues, and he does occasionally save time by assuming the truth of Platonic metaphysics so he can focus on the finer points. But his natural mode is dialectical. He probes problems, seeking to persuade and carry the reader with him, not just to lay out preconceived doctrine. Even when he stretches his inquiry to the limit by trying to understand the One, he asks us to begin by reflecting on familiar things and on ourselves.

Unlike the familiar things of our world, the One must, of course, be incorporeal. Bodies have many parts, and also change over time—so they are multiple in at least two ways. The soul is immaterial and thus has a higher kind of unity. But it too has parts, as Plato already established by pointing to the all-too-familiar phenomenon of inward psychic conflict. Like bodies, it also changes over time. Even the soul's thinking involves change, as it passes from one idea to the next. Which appropriately enough leads us to the next thought: couldn't the first principle be a mind? Not the human soul, perhaps, but an immaterial intellect, that would grasp its knowledge all at once and never do anything else? The suggestion was certainly an option for Plotinus. After all, Aristotle's god is precisely this, a pure intellect that always thinks upon itself. More recently, Platonists like Philo of Alexandria had understood Platonic Forms to be ideas in the mind of God, the cause of all things (see Chapter 23). Plotinus thinks this proposal is on the right track. He agrees that Forms are ideas in a divine mind or Intellect—in Greek, *nous*. He just doesn't think that this Intellect is the first principle, because it falls short of total unity.

It's here that we start to see just how radical is Plotinus' understanding of the One. So radical, in fact, that it's not clear that he or anyone else *can* understand the One. After all, the Forms were always supposed to be the objects that ground all our knowledge. They just are what is knowable, what is intelligible. To make them ideas in a divine Intellect but then say that the One is beyond that Intellect seems to imply that the One cannot be known. For the most part, Plotinus accepts this conclusion. Occasionally he will try to push the boundaries of what language and philosophy can offer (especially in treatise 6.8), but his usual line is that the One is ineffable, that is, beyond anything we can say or think. To say or think anything about it would be to turn it into a multiplicity. For instance, although Plotinus treats this principle as both the One and the Good, if I say something like "the One is good," then I seem to be applying a property to something that has the property (6.9.6). So I'd have two things, the One and its goodness, which are at least conceptually distinct. But the whole point of the One is that it is beyond all multiplicity.

There remains the possibility that the One is accessible to us, but not through language or thought. If we are to reach the One, it would seem that we could only do so by achieving complete unity with it. Porphyry tells us in the biography of his master that Plotinus managed to do this only four times during their time together (23). In Plotinus' writings there are allusions to these experiences, which one can only call mystical. Perhaps the most evocative is the last sentence of one treatise, where Plotinus has asked how we are to reach this origin of all things. He answers his own question with the words *aphele panta*: "take away everything" (5.3.17). But the

prospect of *henosis*, or unification with the One, does not play a central role in the *Enneads*, and tends, in my opinion, to loom larger than it should in discussions of his philosophy. His more important philosophical claim, and more important legacy for later thinkers, is that the One transcends Intellect and the Forms.

This result is paradoxical. Remember, we were looking for ever more intense examples of unity because we observed that unity is correlated with reality, intelligibility, and order. But we've ended by positing a principle beyond intelligibility and order. More paradoxically still, the One is in a sense even beyond reality. Plotinus understands Intellect to be the paradigm of being, and the Forms as the manifold expression of all the sorts of being that there are. The Form of Giraffe is just what it is to be a giraffe, and the Form of Sunflower is the being of sunflowers. Thus Plotinus frequently (for instance at 3.8.9) quotes one of his favorite lines from Plato, a remark Socrates makes about the Form of the Good: the Good is said to be "beyond being in majesty and power" (*Republic* 508b). Plotinus takes Plato to mean that the Good or One is in fact not a Form after all, but transcendent above the realm of Forms, and thus "beyond being."³

The extremes to which Plotinus has led us are apt to make us wonder whether we should have followed him this far. Perhaps we should have stopped with Intellect and its Forms, as Philo of Alexandria did? But that would be to overlook Plotinus' subtle analysis of how Intellect falls short of absolute unity. For one thing, even if it is thinking about all the Forms at once without ever passing from one Form to another, it will still be thinking about many Forms. Indeed, there are presumably an indefinitely large number of Forms—a result that will follow quickly if we accept that there are Forms of numbers.⁴ So Intellect displays an indefinite multiplicity because of the objects of its thought. Plotinus also points out that if the Forms are internal to the Intellect, it will be thinking about itself when it thinks about them (5.5). It is, then, both that which is thinking and that which is being thought. As both subject and object of thought, it has a kind of duality that the truly first principle must lack. Plotinus sums up these findings by calling the Intellect a *hen kai polla*: a "one-and-many" (5.1.8, quoting Plato, *Parmenides* 144e). It has a very impressive degree of unity, being not only immaterial but unchanging and identical with the objects of its own thought. Indeed, it is the most unified thing that can be conceived. But the very fact that it can be conceived, and that it conceives itself, shows that it is not utterly one and is thus not first.

If you still wanted to resist this conclusion, you might offer the following alternative. What if the Forms were not inside the Intellect, as Plotinus is claiming, but distinct from it? Then it could be a simple mind that looks to Forms that are safely outside it, where they would not compromise its oneness. Plato actually says

in the *Timaeus* that god “looks to the Forms” when designing the world (29a), and some Platonists had taken this to mean that the Forms are independent of the divine mind. In fact this was the view Porphyry held when he turned up at Plotinus’ school. As we saw above, he’d been taught it from his earlier instructor, a man named Longinus, who was better known for his linguistic and textual expertise than his philosophical sophistication. Porphyry stuck to Longinus’ position tenaciously and gave in to Plotinus’ view only after a debate with his fellow student Amelius. We are not told what the decisive point in this debate may have been, but in his writings Plotinus offers a powerful reason to think that Intellect is identical with its objects, rather than looking to Forms that are external to it. His argument looks similar to one given by Sextus Empiricus, a rare borrowing from the Skeptical tradition.

The argument begins from the point that whatever grasps an external object has only a representation of that object (5.5.1). For instance, when we see a giraffe cantering across the savannah, the giraffe is not actually in our eye or our eyesight. Rather, we are getting a visual image of the giraffe. But when images are involved there is always a risk of error. A further principle is needed to provide some kind of guarantee, to come along and ratify that the image is accurate. Thus reason frequently corrects the images offered to it in sensation, judging perhaps that that shimmering object just behind the giraffe is not a pool of water, as it seems to be, but rather a mirage. It’s no problem that sensation works like this, but at the level of Intellect it would be a disaster. After all, Intellect was supposed to be the paradigmatic case of knowledge. So how could it need yet a further principle to tell it that its intellection is true? We are in danger of infinite regress, with each kind of cognition needing another kind of cognition to reassure it that it is really getting things right. By insisting that the Forms are inside the Intellect Plotinus avoids this problem: Intellect knows that its knowledge is knowledge, because what it knows is nothing other than itself.

Now, doing philosophy is like taking care of small children. No sooner have you solved one problem than the next problem is looming into view (and we wouldn’t have it any other way). In this case, Plotinus’ success in proving the multiplicity of Intellect leaves us with the puzzle of how the One could possibly have produced something of this sort. The One is supposedly the source of all things. But if it is utterly and completely one, how does it generate something multiple? Later authors, wondering about this aspect of Neoplatonism, invoke the so-called *ex uno unum* principle: from one thing, you only get one thing. And although Plotinus doesn’t explicitly endorse a principle along these lines, he clearly sees it as an important challenge to explain how multiplicity can arise from unity. Unlike Neil Armstrong,

he doesn't try to accomplish this giant leap in just one step. Instead, the production of *nous* from the One is a two-stage process.

First, the simple One allows an equally simple second principle to go forth from itself. This second principle, which will become the Intellect, then turns back upon its source, like a child looking towards its father. In an almost tragic turn of events, it finds that it cannot grasp its father—that would compromise the One's transcendence. Instead it does the next best thing, grasping itself and making itself an image of the One. As it does so it generates the Forms as its ideas, in a single act of intellection that imitates the total simplicity of the One (5.1.7, 5.3.11, 5.4.2). The puzzling thing here, if there is only one puzzling thing, is why this should give rise to the Forms. Plotinus says at one point, "the One is all things, and no one of them" (5.2.1), which I take to mean that the One has the power to generate everything that comes after it, though it remains distinct from everything it generates. Only once Intellect begins to think about itself does it become clear what these things will be. One might further wonder why it is that we get just the Forms that emerge, and not some other Forms. Why is there a Form of Giraffe and no Form of Unicorn? Perhaps our questions are simply wrong-headed, though. Intellect knows whatever there is to know, and this does not include Unicorn, because there is no such thing as a unicorn. This is a matter of necessity. It's not as if Intellect is deciding to think about Giraffe, but giving Unicorn a miss even though it could have thought about that, too. At this level of the Plotinian universe everything that happens is inevitable.

That, of course, brings us to yet another problem. Even if we accept this rather mysterious story about how Intellect is produced by the One, we might be reluctant to accept the idea that it proceeds from the One necessarily. Plotinus uses a variety of metaphors to describe the way Intellect cascades forth from the One. The One is like an overflowing fountain or a shining light. He uses the same language of "emanation" to speak of the production of Soul from Intellect. Subsequently, many philosophers and theologians will complain that this makes the divine principles automatic causes. If the One gives rise to Intellect necessarily, then it is like fire mindlessly giving off heat. Anyone who conceives of the first principle as a generous God, who freely gives a gratuitous gift when He creates the universe, will find this conception disappointing, to say the least. In fact, doubly so. Not only does the One cause its effects necessarily, but it causes most of its effects indirectly. Strictly speaking, it gives rise only to the inchoate subject of thought that will become Intellect when it generates the Forms within itself. Soul is then produced by Intellect, not the One, and the One has only a very distant and mediated relationship to the physical universe. This looks to be a far cry from the voluntary creation of all things envisioned in the Bible and Koran.

And yet Plotinus devoted an ambitious treatise to the freedom of the first principle (6.8). He begins from the nature of human freedom, asking what it means for something to be—as the Stoics liked to put it—“up to us.” He answers that our actions are up to us when we are masters of ourselves, rather than being pulled this way and that by external forces (6.8.1). Of course, he considers the desires and needs that derive from bodily existence to be forces external to our souls. The One, by contrast, has no such competing demands on its attention, and is influenced by nothing outside itself. Strictly speaking, we cannot say that it “masters itself,” because that would introduce the same kind of duality as would arise if it were to think about itself (6.8.12). But we can still say that it is free in the negative sense that nothing is exercising compulsion upon it.

Ironically, then, Plotinus’ conception of freedom does not look that far from what we find in the Stoics, despite their materialism—and in fact among philosophers nowadays with similar inclinations. For him, freedom is simply the power to do what one wishes without hindrance or compulsion exercised by anything else. Again, strictly speaking, we cannot say that the One “wishes” to do anything, but this treatise is notable for Plotinus’ willingness to speak more positively about the One than usual, often adding the caveat *hoion*, meaning “so to speak” or “as if.” Thus, we can say that the One is free because it is “as if” it can act by doing whatever it wants, “so to speak.” We souls, existing at a much lower level of Plotinus’ scheme, can only strive towards the same kind of untrammelled freedom of action. We achieve this above all by—what else?—doing philosophy. Indeed, although Plotinus is perhaps most famous for his ideas about the One, he devotes much more attention to the soul, investigating its powers, the dangers of its relation to the body, and its relationship to the higher principles of Intellect and the One.

ON THE HORIZON

PLOTINUS ON THE SOUL

Wouldn't it be fun to invite an assortment of ancient philosophers to a screening of the *Wizard of Oz*? Just picture the scene. The Stoics would be muttering critically about the Tin Man's deplorable desire to get in touch with his emotions, and pointing out that if the Scarecrow wants to be clever, he should wish for a heart and not a brain. Aristotle would be sitting at the back, taking notes on the winged monkeys for his zoological writings. Galen and the anatomists of Alexandria would tap their toes as the Cowardly Lion launched into their favorite tune, "If I Only Had the Nerve." Thales would feel vindicated by the fact that the heroes win the day by using a bucket of water. Meanwhile the Pythagoreans would be trying to get everyone to be quiet. And Plotinus? I think his favorite scene would come at the end, when Dorothy says: "If I ever go looking for my heart's desire again, I won't look any further than my own backyard. Because if it isn't there, I never really lost it to begin with."

Dorothy's observation might well remind Plotinus of something he says in one of his own treatises: "One might be unaware that one has something, holding onto it more powerfully than if one did know" (4.4.4). He is describing the way that the human soul relates to the things it has seen in the intelligible realm, the realm of the Forms. Following Plato, he believes that the soul is eternal and has seen the wondrous beauty and truth of this realm before it came to be in a body.¹ Yet the embodied soul retains a memory of these realities, and Plotinus here suggests that the deeply buried memory of the Forms is possessed more intensely than the soul's conscious experiences. Thanks to your soul's relationship to a body, it is aware of an almost unceasing stream of sensory phenomena—the whirlwind of colors, motions, and sounds that reach it through the eyes and the ears. It's easy for the soul to be distracted by these fleeting impressions. In its most debased condition, the soul may become so confused as actually to identify itself with the body. But Plotinus believes that even people in this condition have within them the power to remember what they have seen in the world of the intellect.

On this score Plotinus is more optimistic than almost any other late ancient Platonist. Not only does he believe that we can find traces of the intelligible within ourselves; he is convinced that we never depart completely from the intelligible world. The soul remains in part “undescended,” in other words, still actively contemplating the Forms even while it is ensconced in a material body. He knows this idea is controversial and even paradoxical, at one point introducing it with the phrase, “if we may dare to present our own opinion” (4.8.8). After all, as later Platonists like Iamblichus and Proclus pointed out, it’s hard to see how it could be that I am even now engaging in an intellectual vision of the Forms without my being aware of it. But Plotinus is, among other things, a pioneer in the philosophy of awareness. For him, the soul’s challenge is not to achieve union or contact with the intelligible Forms. Rather, the soul needs to realize that it is *already* always in contact with those Forms, and to this extent not just a soul but an intellect. Characteristically, he offers an analogy drawn from everyday experience (1.4.10): when you are concentrating on reading a book, you are not aware that you are reading. Nor does the brave man fighting in battle consciously think that he is being courageous. (The surprisingly Plotinian *Wizard of Oz* incidentally makes the same point: the Cowardly Lion does not realize he is brave, nor is the Tin Man aware of his own compassion.)

Plotinus showed his own compassion by writing the *Enneads*. They are many things—a running engagement on themes and passages in Plato and later thinkers, a conversation with imaginary opponents and his own students, technical treatises suffused with powerful and even poetic imagery. But above all, they constitute an act of charity on Plotinus’ part. He has already identified with his true intellectual self. Porphyry tells us that he could continue to commune with intellect even during a conversation (*Life of Plotinus* 8). So he already has his heart’s desire, and stands to gain nothing personally from straining his bad eyesight to write the treatises collected as the *Enneads*. Much as the One and the intellect spontaneously give rise to the good things that come after them, Plotinus wrote anyway, as an exhortation for his students and readers. The soul is the only part of Plotinus’ universe that could need such an exhortation. The One, of course, reigns in its supreme and silent singularity, while the intellect permanently thinks about the Forms that are its ideas. Below the soul there is the mindless indefiniteness of matter, something we’ll discuss in the next chapter. But the soul, uniquely, is torn between two possibilities. As Plotinus says (4.4.3), it is “on the horizon” of the bodily and the intelligible. The point of philosophy is to turn our attention upwards, away from our bodies and towards the immaterial causes that are more real than any body. Plotinus wants to wake us up, to tell us that there’s no place like home, and that we have never left it.

Plotinus was well aware of philosophical rivals who denied the reality of Forms or a world of intellect, who even denied the immateriality of the soul itself. He finds it hard to take the Epicureans seriously, so his main opponents here are the Stoics. Despite being cleverer than any Scarecrow, they were convinced that they, or their souls, were nothing but material objects. Plotinus is happy to set up Stoic materialism as a straw man to be knocked down, and also directs his fire at Aristotle's claim that the soul is the form of the body (4.3.20, 4.7.8, 6.7.4). Against such views, Plotinus argues in a variety of ways for soul's independence as an incorporeal substance. As so often, he focuses on unity. The body has separate parts, whereas the soul does not. For one thing, the soul can grasp immaterial objects of thought, and he fails to see how something with separate parts could grasp something that has no parts. He draws a similar conclusion from the soul's awareness of what is happening in the body. After all, it is not as if we have one soul in our finger to perceive things that happen to the finger, and another soul in some other part of the body (4.1.2). Rather, the soul is a unified locus of awareness for the entire body. He dismisses Stoic attempts to explain this via some kind of chain-reaction of physical signals through the body, to a so-called "ruling faculty" seated in the heart. If that were the case there would be only an indirect perception of what happens in the finger, whereas Plotinus wants to insist that the soul is wholly and immediately aware of each bodily experience. On the other hand, when he gives his own theory of perception he insists that the soul cannot actually be *affected* by anything that happens in the body (3.6.1).² Rather, the single soul makes a discrimination or judgment on the basis of material events that happen in the sense organs.

Rather ironically, given Plotinus' scorn for Stoic materialism, the philosopher who comes closest to anticipating his ideas about the self is probably the Stoic Epictetus. Stoics had long held that the rational part of each person stands in judgment over the impressions of sense-experience. And in Stoic ethics, especially Epictetus—who lived only a few generations before Plotinus—we found the idea that the true self is the reasoning aspect of the person, and that wisdom consists in valuing this true self rather than apparent bodily goods like wealth, food, pleasurable experience, or even physical health (see Chapter 13). Plotinus endorses these Stoic ideas, but draws more radical conclusions. In the treatise that Porphyry placed at the very beginning of the *Enneads* (1.1), Plotinus asks who "we" are, thus tackling the question of the self more directly than any philosopher had done before. As we would by now expect, he concludes that our true self is the higher aspect of soul that engages in intellection, and not the self of bodily experience.

In a remarkable final paragraph (1.1.13), though, Plotinus wonders who it is that is inquiring into the identity of the self. Is that really "us"? There is a paradox lurking

here: if the real “me” is the “me” who is always contemplating the Forms, then whose attention needs to be turned to the Forms? Apparently, not my own attention, since I am really only my intellectual self, whether the lower, incidental part of me knows it or not. As usual in Plotinus, the solution lies in unity. I should be trying not just to figure out which part of me is the real me, but to make all of me into a single, self-aware being. That means continuing to have bodily experiences, but to recognize these experiences for the incidental, fleeting, valueless things that they are—and also to understand how they relate to my higher self. So Plotinus can also say that my “self” is that which becomes aware of both its higher and its lower nature. The goal is to integrate and unify these two aspects, by doing some philosophy and thus obeying the Delphic command, “Know thyself.”

Does this mean that the soul has no nature of its own by which it is distinguished from both body and intellect? Or is it nothing but a center of attention that can look up or down? For all his talk of soul as existing on a horizon, Plotinus does think that some activities exist properly at the level of soul. Above all, the activity of discursive reasoning (in Greek, *dianoia*). He sharply distinguishes this kind of thinking from the intellection (*noesis*) that we find in the case of Intellect or *nous*. Whereas *nous* grasps all possible objects of knowledge all at once, it is characteristic of soul to think first about one thing then about something else. Those of us who find it hard to think about even one thing at a time may find this impressive enough, but for Plotinus the soul’s reasoning activity is a mere image of the perfect thinking of Intellect. Still, we shouldn’t be too discouraged. Soul does manage to think about the same things as Intellect, albeit in a more laborious and partial way. We can thus consider the soul’s discursive thought to be a kind of unfolding or piecemeal spelling out of the undivided, complete knowledge possessed by Intellect.

The fact that soul re-enacts the activity of Intellect in a lesser, more divided way has far-reaching consequences in Plotinus’ philosophy. For one thing, it allows him to give a novel theory of time and to explain how time relates to eternity (3.7). As so often in late ancient Platonism, the touchstone text here is Plato’s *Timaeus*. There we learn that time comes about along with the orderly motions of the heavens in the physical cosmos, whereas eternity is appropriate to immaterial beings like the Forms and the divine craftsman. Plato also has *Timaeus* say that time is the “moving image of eternity” (37d). With his distinction between the all-at-once activity of Intellect and the one-thing-after-another activity of soul, Plotinus is able to explain Plato’s remarks as follows. Eternity is the “life of Intellect” (3.7.3). It is simply a name for the way that Forms are all simultaneously and permanently grasped in the Intellect’s contemplation. Time is correspondingly the “life of soul.”

Since we are souls, we have an intimate experience of time as we go through our sequential thought processes. To say that our thinking is “discursive” is just to say that it happens in time—to think at one time about one thing, and then at another time about something else. Suppose you are following a philosophical argument. You consider each premise in turn and then see that a conclusion follows from these premises. Or consider the more homely example of reading this chapter. You aren’t thinking about the ideas I’m trying to explain all at once, but one idea after another. First you pondered the *Wizard of Oz*, then you contemplated the undescended soul, and now you’re wondering what to have for dinner, because your mind started wandering about two paragraphs ago. (Don’t feel bad, it happens to all of us.) Because this discursive kind of thinking is an image or unfolding of the Intellect’s comprehension, Plotinus can say that Plato was right. Time is indeed an image of eternity.

For Plotinus, then, eternity is not simply unending time. On his theory, if you pledge to love someone forever you aren’t, strictly speaking, pledging to love them “eternally.” You’re only promising to love them at every moment of future time. Plotinian eternity, by contrast, doesn’t mean “at every moment,” whether past, present, or future. It means timelessness. Plotinus’ theory itself achieved a kind of timelessness, being embraced by many generations of philosophers in Neoplatonism and beyond. Christian thinkers like Boethius and Aquinas, for instance, will gladly agree that God is beyond time and has His knowledge all at once (for Boethius see Chapter 53). Though Plotinus’ idea of eternity was thus very influential, the way he tries to convey the idea can be puzzling. Though he will say that the notions of “before” and “after” do not apply to the eternal Intellect, he still applies words like “always” to it, and at one point even says that “it always was and always will be” (5.8.12). This sounds like he is applying temporal concepts to eternity after all, though he does immediately warn us that the words he is using are misleading.³

A further problem is that he thinks the soul and physical universe must be everlasting, that is, infinite in past and future time. He thinks this will make them the best possible image of eternity. But it’s hard to see why that should be so. If eternity really means the *absence* of duration, why should infinite duration be a more faithful image of eternity than temporary duration? Indeed, how could any kind of duration be an image of something that totally lacks duration? And there’s yet another puzzle here, regarding soul’s relationship to intellect. He keeps telling us that, as souls, our goal is to realize our connection to intellect. But insofar as we are consciously thinking like the intellect, our thinking is eternal and timeless—how, then, does it get lost and regained? Perhaps for this reason, Plotinus de-emphasizes the Platonic theory of recollection.⁴ Plato’s idea, that when the soul grasps Forms it

remembers something it used to have but has temporarily forgotten, doesn't fit very well with Plotinus' claim that an intellectual grasp of Forms must be timeless.

This brings us to a further consequence of Plotinus' contrast between Intellect and soul. Since Intellect is the realm of Forms, it must be recognized as an ultimate cause of the physical universe. But it does not relate to the universe directly. Rather, it uses the soul like an assistant, which is responsible for putting images of the Forms into material bodies. To understand how this works, we need to think about two closely connected contrasts that are central in Plotinus' system: internal and external activity, and procession and reversion. Plotinus illustrates the first contrast with the example of fire (5.4.2). A flame has its essential, internal activity of burning and being hot. But it also has an external activity—the influence it has on other things by warming them up. In just the same way, the soul has an internal and an external activity. Internally, it engages in its special kind of discursive thinking about the Forms. But externally, it bestows these very same Forms on physical objects, insofar as it is able. Plotinus does not understand these two activities as being in tension, as if the soul would be distracted from thinking about giraffes by the task of actually making physical giraffes. Rather, the external activity is an automatic result of the internal activity—and the result will always be weaker, just as fire causes a warmth that is weaker than its own heat.⁵

That brings us on to procession and reversion. Given the theory of double activity, each level in Plotinus' system is automatically going to give forth some kind of effect. In Neoplatonic jargon, this automatic causation is called "procession." Even the One, despite its transcendence, seems to obey this model. It remains simple and inviolate in itself, which is a kind of internal activity. But it also emanates an external effect, which becomes Intellect (5.2.1). When we were looking at that process in the last chapter, we said that Intellect generates the Forms when it turns back towards its source. This moment of turning back is "reversion." Everything in Plotinus' system reverts back to its cause, apart from the One itself, since it has no cause. Soul looks to its intellectual father, just as Intellect looks to the One. If procession is leaving home, reversion is coming back and asking Mom to do your laundry. But inevitably we wind up doing the laundry ourselves, and not as well either—we mix the dark and the light fabrics. Intellect doesn't quite get back to the One and has to perform an activity of its own, internally contemplating the many Forms and externally giving rise to soul. Similarly the soul reverts on Intellect, and the result is its internal discursive thinking and its external, processive ordering of the physical universe. In both cases the activities fall short of the higher perfection found at the level of their causes, and give rise to a lower external effect.

Now, when Plotinus talks about the soul ordering the physical universe, he doesn't primarily have in mind souls like yours or mine. Our souls are "partial" or "individual," and relate specifically to one body. Yet again following Plato's *Timaeus*, Plotinus believes that the entire cosmos has a single soul—the so-called World Soul. It is this soul that is responsible for arranging things that seem to have no soul, or barely any: things like plants and rocks. But Plotinus insists that even rocks are animated, observing that this is why minerals grow within the earth (6.7.11). The World Soul, in combination with the many partial souls present in humans and animals, ensures that the Forms in intellect are represented at the level of bodies. The details of this process are somewhat obscure. One of the thornier problems in Plotinus is whether individual humans, or any other kind of individual, exist at the level of *nous*. Does the Intellect contain a Form of Socrates and another Form of Buster Keaton, or only the Form of Man, which is imitated by many images in this world? Plotinus wrote a whole treatise on this question (5.7), but his considered opinion remains difficult to nail down.⁶

What is more certain is that when the Forms get their physical images, the result is far inferior to the original. The Form of Man is indivisible, eternal, and perfect, whereas even Buster Keaton was nothing of the sort, never mind the rest of us. This can in part be explained by the fact that the things we see in our world are mere images, made by a soul instead of being grasped through perfect intellectual contemplation. But this can't be the full explanation. Plotinus believes that the World Soul too is a sort of divinity, and that it exercises providence in arranging the universe. So how does it come about that the cosmos is so rife with evil, with suffering and ugliness? (The Wicked Witch of the West put it best: "What a world, what a world!") Plotinus rose to this challenge with an explanation of evil so powerful that it will echo down through later antiquity and medieval times.

A DECORATED CORPSE PLOTINUS ON MATTER AND EVIL

Are you a pessimistic sort of person? When you look at a glass that has been filled to the halfway point with water, do you think, “Water? Is that the best they can offer me?” When life gives you lemons, do you make lemonade, but then refuse to drink it, realizing you would really have preferred the water after all? Among the seven dwarfs in *Snow White*, do you most identify with Grumpy? Most of the dwarfs seem to have no sophisticated views about the world, contenting themselves with sneezing or sleeping. Dopey more or less sets the tone. Happy is an exception, but he is clearly deluding himself. At least Grumpy has the courage to face the world as it is. It’s a world of wicked stepmothers, of poisonous apples with worms in them. Grumpy knows that life can be a nightmare, and that Prince Charming is not coming to wake us up.

The undeniable fact that the world around us is full of suffering and evil has always presented a challenge to philosophers of a more optimistic bent. In contemporary philosophy it is most familiar in the form of the so-called “problem of evil.”¹ Actually there are several problems of evil, only two of which really feature in philosophy nowadays. The starker of these two is called the “logical” problem of evil, and claims that there is a straightforward contradiction between the existence of evil and the existence of a perfectly good, all-powerful, and all-knowing God. The thought is that a God who was perfectly good would want to avoid any evil that He knew about and could avoid. But the God we’re considering knows everything and can do anything, so there can’t be any evil that escapes His notice or His power. Yet we see that there is evil. Thus God, at least as described, doesn’t exist. Since the God of Judaism, Christianity, and Islam seems to fit the description—perfectly good, omniscient, and omnipotent—the logical problem of evil accuses adherents of these faiths of a rather fundamental error. They believe both that God exists and that evil exists, which is simply a contradiction.

I tend to think that philosophers of religion have succeeded in answering this version of the problem of evil. Remember, this version of the problem states that there is *no possible* way that such a God and evil could coexist. But this seems wrong. God might well have reasons for tolerating the existence of evil, despite His perfect goodness. The standard reason offered is that if God wanted to give us free will He might allow evil to exist as a consequence of this freedom. That doesn't end the debate, of course. We might think that God, being all-knowing and all-powerful, could find a way to create free creatures without evil ever resulting. Here the philosophical issues get rather difficult,² but suffice it to say that with the logical version of the problem the burden lies on the anti-theist to show that the theist's beliefs are actually contradictory or impossible. That's quite a high standard to reach. Thus the anti-theist may be well advised to retrench to a second version, the so-called "evidential" problem of evil. On this version, we admit that God theoretically *might* allow evil to exist, but we say that the amount and type of evil we actually see in the world makes it vanishingly *unlikely* that there is a perfect God. The evidence at our disposal seems to include pointless evils that a perfect God would have eliminated. Here, the burden of argument between theist and anti-theist is much more evenly distributed.

These two versions of the problem of evil need to be distinguished from the problem that was of interest to Plotinus, and to the centuries of philosophers who followed in his wake. I would call it the "metaphysical" problem of evil. It goes like this. Plotinus, and many a thinker after him, believed that all things derive from a first principle, which is perfectly good. Indeed, he called his first principle not only "the One" but also "the Good": as the source of all things, it is the source of whatever is good and is thus to be identified with goodness itself. But how can anything evil derive from something that is purely Good? This would be as if the Form of Horse caused some things not to be horses, or if water made things dry. So Plotinus' problem of evil is really a problem about *causation*. We need to explain how evil effects can arise from good causes. Actually, even that's not quite right. Plotinus isn't exclusively, or for that matter mostly, concerned with moral evil. The Greek word he uses, *kakon*, means "bad" in a broader sense, and for Plotinus it describes any defective state, such as illness or deformity. In fact, his most common example of something bad is not moral evil, but ugliness. So what he really wants to explain is how there can be anything bad in a world derived from good causes. His basic answer, paradoxical though it may seem, is that this can't happen, and so there is nothing bad in the world.

This is in part because the causes of Plotinus' universe are not merely abstract causes, like Plato's Forms seem to be: they are benevolent, providential gods. One of

his most powerful treatises, split into two by Porphyry (3.2–3) and placed at the beginning of the third *Ennead* along with a briefer work on fate (3.1), is devoted to the subject of providence. Here Plotinus develops the optimistic world-view of the Stoics, insisting that misfortunes and evils are beneficial and good when seen from the wider divine perspective. For instance, in one rather appalling passage Plotinus speculates that men who rape women will be reincarnated as women who are themselves raped (3.2.13). On the other hand, he rejects the Stoic conviction that all events are determined by an irresistible divine providence. When I was discussing Stoic determinism (in Chapter 10), I mentioned that Plotinus says that determinism makes humans like stones that have been set rolling. Plotinus thinks this mistake goes hand in hand with another Stoic error, namely their understanding of humans as entirely material beings.

For Plotinus, our ability to transcend determination by physical causes is due to the immateriality of our souls—since they cannot be affected by mere bodies, we are guaranteed independence and self-determination. So long, that is, as we do not fall under the sway of our bodies, succumbing to the lure of pleasure and bodily needs. Freedom, for Plotinus, means identifying ourselves with our immaterial and, ultimately, our intellectual selves. This may seem rather puzzling, insofar as Plotinus seems to be telling us that we will be free if, and only if, we make this choice and no other choice. But for Plotinus freedom is not about being able to choose between one thing rather than another. After all, he considers the One to be free, even though the One necessarily and eternally causes its effects, without selecting this from a menu of options. Rather, for Plotinus an action is “up to us” if we are the cause determining the action. The One can never be so determined, since no cause can affect it. We, by contrast, can be enslaved by the body, but only if we let it enslave us.

These Stoic-flavored meditations on providence and self-determination do little to persuade us that evil does not exist. At best, they show merely that evils are woven into the fabric of a cosmic tapestry that is, on the whole, good. But Plotinus has a more decisive card to play. Of course, he does admit that bad things happen. But there is no such *thing* as badness. Strictly speaking, it has no being (1.8, 2.4.16). Rather, badness (or if you prefer, “evil”) is always a mere lack or deficiency, which is found within something that has a degree of goodness. To put it another way, badness is when something fails to be as good as it *ought* to be. But something that was not good in any way at all simply could not exist. The giraffe may be sick and cantankerous, and these are deficiencies—a healthy, playfully cooperative giraffe would be better. But the giraffe still has its life, its ability to move, to see. These capacities, however impaired they may be, remain good, and if they were all stripped away there would be no giraffe. And likewise for any case of imperfection you care

to name, including moral evil. When the evil Queen tries to poison Snow White, this is a failure of her rationality or self-control (1.8.4). But without her crafty mind and her basic ability to act she could do nothing, evil or otherwise.

Evils are thus the holes in the Swiss cheese of the universe. They are not things in their own right that the divine causes have brought into being. Rather, they are precisely cases where the divine causes have *not* brought something into being, or rather, have brought less into being than we might have hoped. Thus there is no accusation to place at the doorstep of the gods. They have not made evils, because evils are not the sort of thing that can be made. This is, I would say, a breathtakingly clever and original solution to the *metaphysical* problem of evil. It was recognized as such by many subsequent philosophers, notably St Augustine (see Chapter 47). He adopted the Plotinian theory of evil and passed it on to the medieval tradition, where it became a standard part of the argumentation used to absolve God of responsibility for evil. Still, one might feel that Plotinus' theory is itself lacking something. Even if we grant that evils are not beings in their own right but mere deficiencies, isn't there still a puzzle as to why the effects of perfect causes should be imperfect and deficient at all?

Plotinus would admit that there is, but he has a final move to make, an explanation for why the images of Forms we find in this world are not as perfect as the Forms themselves. In a way, the answer is obvious. Since deficiency is found not in the intelligible world but only in the material world, the culprit must be matter (1.8.7, 13). Our sick giraffe is like a wobbly table, made by an expert carpenter working with poor-quality wood. This idea—that matter is somehow incapable of receiving form perfectly—has a certain plausibility. It's clear that a material object will differ from an intelligible paradigm in some ways. Even the best giraffe or table in our world will have parts, will occupy space, and be subject to change over time. None of these things apply to the Form of Giraffe or the Form of Table, and for Plotinus they already constitute a falling away from perfection. Remember that he sees a close connection between unity and goodness. So for him, just having parts and changing from one moment to the next is already a way of being worse than the Form.

Still, we might think it possible for each material object to be the best possible *material* version of its Form—all giraffes would be equally healthy and elegant, all tables equally well made, all humans equally virtuous. Why doesn't this happen? It looks like Plotinus' theory needs matter to be resistant to perfection, somehow recalcitrant and prone to undermining unity and proportion. That would be hard to understand from the perspective of someone like Aristotle, who thinks of matter as nothing but potentiality for form. For an Aristotelian, the whole point of matter

is to become perfected in various ways. But Plotinus rejects this rather positive idea of matter, and goes so far as to describe matter as a sort of non-being (1.8.7, 2.5.5). This is the core of his solution, because it shows why matter is intimately involved with badness—also a kind of non-being. It also explains why a material universe must involve failures to receive form and being. Plotinus insists that matter cannot, as Aristotle claimed, be actualized or perfected. Rather, it remains inert and unaffected, even as higher causes try to give it form (3.6).

The result is a radical rethinking of the physical reality around us. Bodies may seem to us solid and real. But they are only a conjunction of matter, which is in itself nothing at all, with incorporeal images that are weak imitations of the Forms. Our worldly experience is of these mere images, flickering through the darkness of matter without actually turning the matter into anything real. Plotinus compares the images to reflections in a mirror or ghosts (3.6.7), and in a wonderful turn of phrase, describes matter as a “decorated corpse” (2.4.5). The images are often beautiful, because they are, after all, imitations of the perfect Forms in the intellect. Yet Plotinus compares the situation to a prisoner who has been bound in chains of gold (1.8.15). Thus, his theory is often summarized as the claim that matter and evil are the same thing. But it would be more accurate to say that matter is the *principle* of evils.³ In itself matter is nothing at all, whereas any given case of evil is a specific deficiency that results when the death, darkness, and indeterminacy of matter undermines the reception of a specific form in a specific body.

All this seems to be aimed at explaining natural evils, like illness and deformation, rather than the evil found within us humans. In fact, you might suppose that Plotinus will have a hard time explaining moral evil. If humans are really immaterial souls, how can they be subject to the deficiency and imperfection caused by matter? The answer is: indirectly. Matter is still the cause of human weakness, because for a soul weakness is nothing but turning towards bodies and away from its true intelligible home. Again, this might look rather inadequate. Does Plotinus really have nothing to say about human evil and goodness, apart from telling us to stop paying attention to bodies? Remember that this is the man who took care of orphans and tried to found a city governed by Platonic theories of justice. Events in our world were clearly not a matter of indifference to him.

He can, I think, explain how and why humans can be practically virtuous in terms of the theory of matter and evil we’ve been discussing. Even though matter can never be redeemed by the imitations of Form that appear in it, it’s obviously better for Form to be imitated as fully as possible. So, just as it’s preferable that a giraffe be healthy rather than sick, it’s preferable that we act virtuously rather than viciously. Indeed, the wise man’s virtuous actions will be a natural result of his wisdom.

Because the wise man grasps the Form of Justice, for instance, he will seek to instantiate justice in the material realm. There still lurks a paradox here, in that wise people would really prefer to spend all their time contemplating the intelligible Forms. But Plotinus' view is that our embodied condition just doesn't allow that. In one of my favorite passages in the *Enneads* (6.8.5), he says that a man who fights bravely in a war is like Hippocrates healing a sick person. Hippocrates would prefer that the patient weren't ill in the first place, and the brave man would likewise prefer that his city didn't need to be defended. But given that there is illness, that the city is besieged by the enemy, the appropriate action follows naturally from the brave man's virtue or the doctor's skill.

We can't give Plotinus' theory of evil a clean bill of health just yet. He's done all this work to explain how matter undermines the reception of goodness, and seduces the soul away from its true calling. But now we seem forced to ask: where did matter come from? After all, if the chain of emanated principles had gone from the One to Intellect, then to Soul, and then just stopped, we wouldn't have all these problems. Of course, the question of where matter comes from is a slightly odd one, given that matter is non-being. Rather than saying that some cause brought about all this nothingness, Plotinus might (and sometimes does) just compare it to the way light must eventually give out, leaving darkness where the power of the light-source can no longer reach (1.8.4). But he also suggests that matter should somehow derive from higher principles. His considered view on this is a matter of debate. Some interpreters think that, for Plotinus, matter is the product of soul, simply the last in the chain of direct emanations. On this reading, the soul is too weak to originate anything with a causal power of its own, so it makes inert, dead matter instead. Another possibility is that matter emerges from the Intellect itself.⁴

But whatever the mechanism, it's clear what Plotinus absolutely wants to avoid: the idea that matter is an independent, evil principle that would counterbalance the first principle Plotinus calls the One or the Good. We already saw that Plutarch was tempted by this sort of dualist theory, which posits an evil principle that undermines all the good work done by the gods in our world. But when Plotinus thinks about dualism he has in mind another opponent: the Gnostics.⁵ They were a religious sect with an elaborate, moralizing cosmological theory that could well be compared to that of Plotinus himself. We are fortunate in knowing a good deal about them, thanks especially to twentieth-century discoveries of manuscripts in Egypt. These texts, preserved in the Coptic language, tell us that the physical universe is the product of an ignorant and erring divinity, and that only an elite few souls are chosen to escape from cycles of rebirth in the prison of bodies.

We know that works by Gnostic authors were read in the circle of Plotinus, and Porphyry actually entitled one of the treatises in the *Enneads* “Against the Gnostics” (2.9, actually a part of the so-called *Großschrift*). A second title given to this treatise by Porphyry is revealing: “Against Those Who Say that the Maker of the Universe, and the Universe, are Evil.” Here Porphyry understood well the teachings of his master. Plotinus may have made matter the principle of evil, but he was adamantly opposed to the idea that the physical cosmos as a whole is evil, or that it would be better if it did not exist. His praise of the divine providence that governs this cosmos was just as passionate as his insistence that we should identify ourselves with the highest, intellectual part of our souls. His conviction that we do have such a part—and that all of us do, not only an elect few, as the Gnostics claimed—is another sign of Plotinus’ deep optimism. He saw the physical world as imperfect in its details but perfect as a whole, as a danger to souls, but a danger that we can defeat.

Before we move on to Porphyry himself, a final word about Plotinus. In recent decades he, and Neoplatonism in general, have increasingly been embraced by historians of philosophy. It was not always so, and in the popular imagination Neoplatonism may still be associated with mystical anti-philosophy and “the irrational.” I hope the next several chapters will show that this would be an inaccurate assessment even of later Neoplatonism, and that the last several have shown that it certainly does not apply to Plotinus. He may often reach for metaphor and rhetorical gesture, and admit that human reason falls short of understanding the highest realities. But his writing is distinguished above all by restlessly probing argument, offered in careful engagement with his dialectical opponents, his students, and his readers. The best description of his approach may be the one he himself gives when he is contrasting himself to the Gnostics: “the kind of philosophy which we pursue, besides all its other excellences, displays simplicity and straightforwardness of character along with clear thinking, and aims at dignity, not rash arrogance, and combines its confident boldness with reason and much safeguarding and caution and a great deal of circumspection: you are to use philosophy of this kind as a standard of comparison for the rest” (2.9.14, Armstrong trans.).